STATE SCAN

GOA: YATRA OF HOPE FOR CONGRESS *PG 16*

MP: BHOPAL, NOW A CONCRETE TRAGEDY *PG 18*



BITTER PILL TO SWALLOW Parvinder Singh Jhota in Gubara village, Malerkotla, Feb. 2024; (inset) the live-streamed confrontation in which he was shot to death

▶ PUNJAB

A BULLET THROUGH MANN'S PROMISE

The murder of an anti-drug activist raises questions about the chief minister's claims of his war on narcotics

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

IT'S BEEN A DECADE SINCE *UDTA PUNJAB* GAVE NATIONAL PLAY to the state's drug crisis. It gradually slipped off the front pages, surviving more as a spicy accessory to political news, or as well-trodden context that didn't need to be reiterated. But October 13 brought a shattering reminder that the crisis had never really gone away. Parvinder Singh Jhota, 45, a former national-level boxer who had turned into an anti-drug crusader and social media influencer rolled into one, was shot dead in a chemist shop in Mansa—and the act was shot live on his own camera that was streaming it to the world. Laced with grittier drama than cinema, this time the topic may make a frontal ambush on politics, given that elections are within firing range.

How stretched the Bhagwant Mann government will be to show the results it had promised was clear a day later, when a municipal excavator razed the front of chemist Ashwani Kumar's house in Mansa. The same day, Ashwani, the one seen on camera shooting down Jhota, was arrested from a *dharamshala* (resthouse) in Churu,